

The Archive of False Flags

Walkthrough / evidence note by **Wiseguy**

CASE BRIEF

A suspicious archive was recovered from an abandoned server. The extracted directory contains several strings that look like valid flags. **Many of them are fake flags deliberately planted as decoys.** The task is therefore not just to locate a flag-shaped string, but to validate the evidence and identify the real one.

Objective: enumerate the archive completely, inspect hidden or unusual artifacts, recover the encoded transmission value, decode it, and verify the final flag.

Category	Forensics / Archive Analysis
Key idea	Enumeration + hidden file inspection + hex decoding
Main trap	Multiple believable but fake flags
Useful clue	"find command maybe useful"

01 / ENUMERATE EVERYTHING

After extracting the archive, do not trust only the visible filenames. The clue points toward **find**, which recursively enumerates files and helps expose dotfiles that are easy to overlook.

```
unzip challenge.zip -d challenge
cd challenge
find . -type f
```

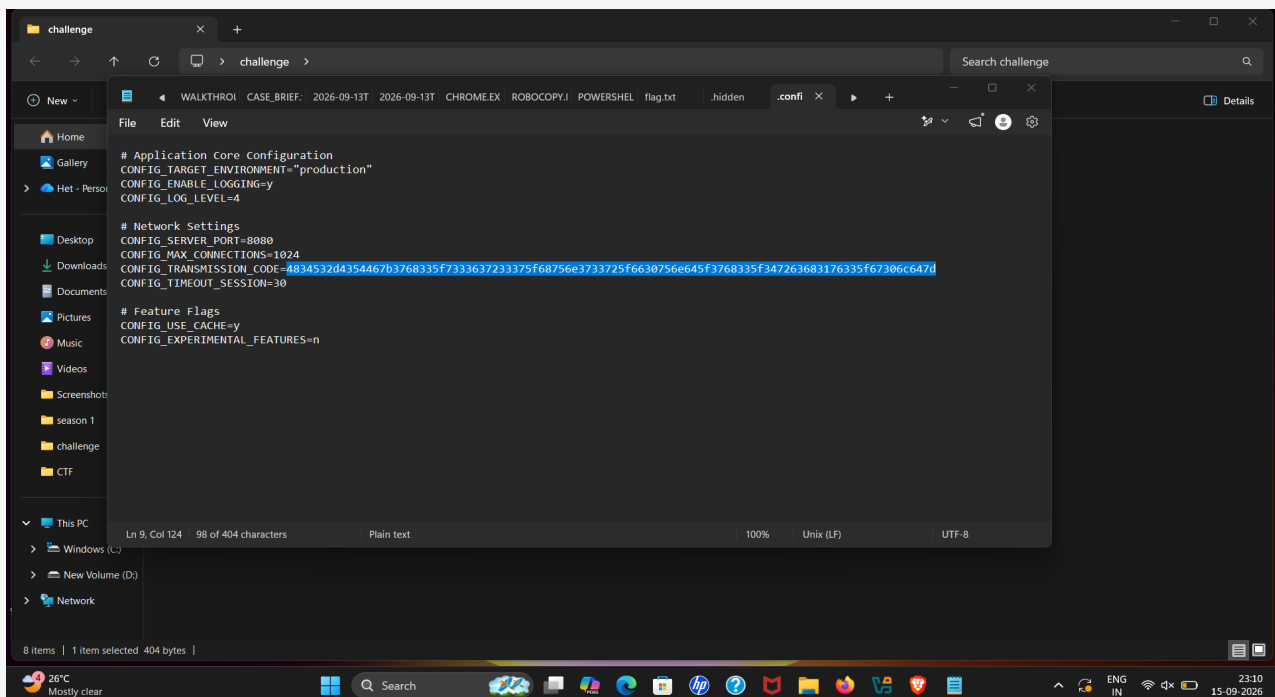
Several recovered strings use the correct flag format but are intentional decoys:

```
H4S-CTF{hidden_somewhere_else}
H4S-CTF{$3crets_aren0t_h3r3}
H4S-CTF{n0t_@_r34l_fl4g}
H4S-CTF{pl4c3h0ld3r_0nly}
```

A correctly formatted string is not automatically valid evidence. The wording of these fake flags is itself a signal to continue the investigation.

02 / THE HIDDEN CONFIGURATION

Enumeration reveals the hidden **.config** file. Most entries resemble normal application settings, but **CONFIG_TRANSMISSION_CODE** contains a long hexadecimal-looking sequence.



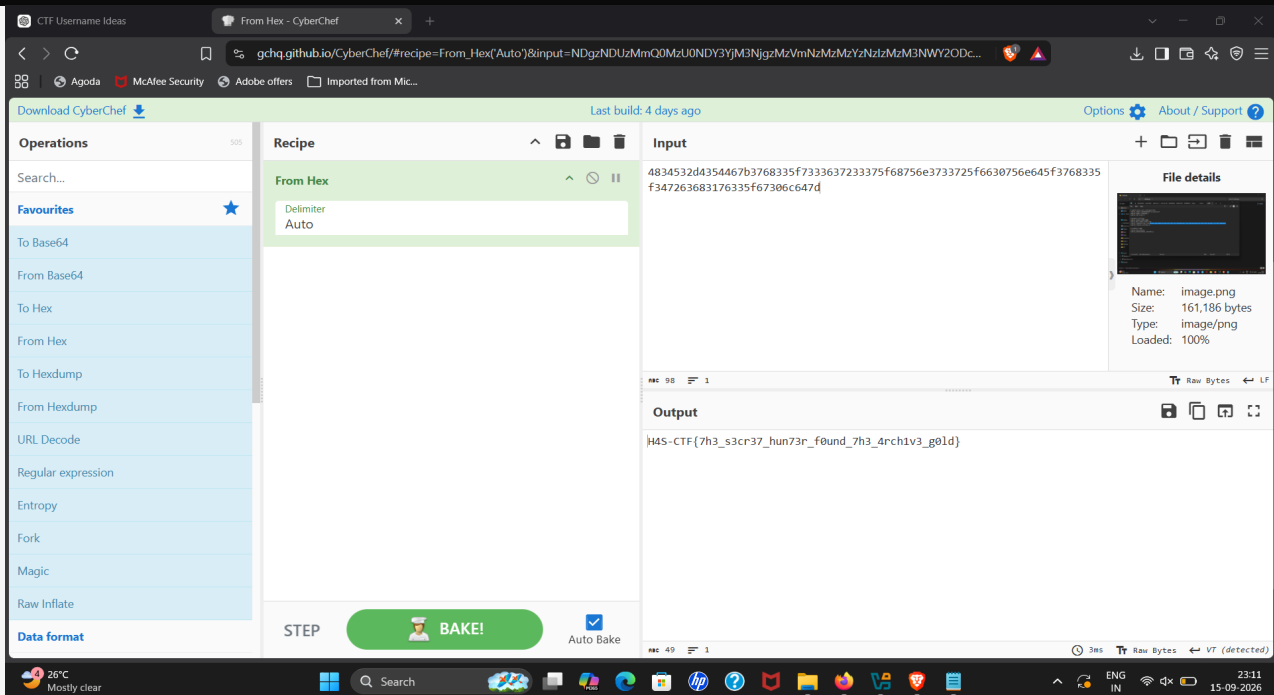
Evidence 01 — Hidden .config file with CONFIG_TRANSMISSION_CODE highlighted.

The sequence consists of valid hexadecimal byte pairs. This makes decoding it the logical next step rather than treating it as another flag or a password hash.

03 / DECODE THE TRANSMISSION

The transmission value can be decoded in Kali using **xxd**, or in CyberChef with the **From Hex** operation.

```
echo "4834532d4354467b3768335f7333637233375f68756e3733725f6630756e645f3768335f347263683176335f67306c647d" | xxd -r -p
```



Evidence 02 — CyberChef From Hex operation revealing the readable flag.

RECOVERED FLAG

H4S-CTF{7h3_s3cr37_hun73r_f0und_7h3_4rch1v3_g0ld}

04 / WHY THE FAKE FLAGS MATTER

The important forensic lesson is evidence validation. The archive intentionally rewards anyone who keeps investigating instead of submitting the first flag-shaped string they encounter. File context, the challenge clue, hidden-file discovery, and successful decoding all support the final result.

Workflow: extract → enumerate → inspect hidden files → reject decoys → identify encoding → decode → validate final flag.

COMMAND SUMMARY

```
unzip challenge.zip -d challenge
cd challenge
find . -type f
cat .config
echo "<hex_value>" | xxd -r -p
```

Conclusion: the archive contains multiple fake flags. The real evidence is the encoded CONFIG TRANSMISSION CODE stored inside the hidden .config file; decoding it produces the final flag.